

## Phylogeny by sound changes: South-Central Tibeto-Burman

Linguistic phylogeny is based on identifying shared innovations in related languages, and regular sound changes are considered one of the most reliable innovations for this purpose. However, the challenge of differentiating between shared innovations and parallel innovations remains a vexed problem for sound changes. The fate of two phonemes / phoneme sequences in Proto-South-Central Tibeto-Burman (Proto-SCTB), a.k.a. Proto-Kuki-Chin, illustrates this challenge vividly: \*k(h)r and \*θ.

Table 1. Correspondence sets for VanBik's (2009) reconstruction of \*k(h)r and \*θ, organized by sub-groups from Peterson (2017). Central Halam added from my fieldwork (2025-26).

| Proto-SCTB | North-Eastern | South-Eastern | Khumi | Core Central           | Mara | Central Halam |
|------------|---------------|---------------|-------|------------------------|------|---------------|
| *kr        | *k            | *k(y)         | v     | *tr > *t               | ts   | *ts           |
| *khr       | *kh           | *kh(y)        | h     | *thr > *t <sup>h</sup> | tsh  | *s (< *tsh)   |
| *θ         | *ts           | *θ            | ts    | *f                     | s    | *s            |

Here, Central Halam which is my working terminology for certain varieties spoken in North-Eastern Tripura and Southern Assam in North-East India, e.g. Chorei, Ranglong, Sakachep and Langkai, appears to group with Mara. This putative Mara-Halam branch may, in turn, share the \*k(h)r > \*t(h)r (> \*ts(h) in Mara-Halam) sound change with Core Central. However, Konnerth (2022:316) argued that the \*k(h)r > (\*t(h)r >) \*t<sup>(h)</sup> sound change is quite common among Tibeto-Burman languages and therefore, it may have taken place in multiple sub-branches of SCTB independently. A similar argument can be advanced against accepting \*t(h)r > \*ts(h) as being shared between Mara and Central Halam too. This change may be quite trivial inside SCTB since voiceless /r/ often has a fricative realization acoustically similar to [s] in these languages.

In a similar vain, \*θ > \*s in Mara and Central Halam may be considered to be too trivial to give evidence of sub-grouping. However, Hill (2014:17) suggested that \*θ should be (phonetically) revised to \*dz. If that revision is accepted, the \*dz > \*s change would not be as trivial, and would therefore be a candidate for a shared innovation. Alternatively, an intermediate \*dz > \*θ sound change may well be a shared innovation between Core Central, Mara and Central Halam.

In summary, it is observed that certain sound changes may be more common in the history of a language family than cross-linguistically expected – presumably because of certain phonetic features of the relevant proto-phoneme and/or the over-all phonological structure of the proto-language make these developments more likely (cf. Iosad 2025). More generally, a sufficiently detailed phonetic reconstruction of the proto-phonemes is necessary to be able to use regular sound changes as the basis of linguistic sub-grouping within a family. Even more broadly, the understanding of cross-linguistic frequencies of individual sound-changes must also take the phonetics of the reconstructed proto-phonemes into account.

## References

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